

At age 70, most successful entrepreneurs are happily spending their days on golf courses or yachts. Bob Campana was drinking Red Bull and looking for his next mountain to climb. The phone rang. It was the executive assistant for Susan Dell'Osso, the CEO of The Cambay Group, the masterminds behind "River Islands"—a staggering, 8-square-mile, 15,000-home mega-development in Northern California. Susan wanted a meeting. When they walked a construction site together, Susan explained that she was sick of homogenized, copy-and-paste California subdivisions. She wanted to build a vibrant, upscale town center around a lake, and she needed a world-class restaurant to anchor it. She didn't want a corporate chain; she wanted Bob's unique Redwood Café, and she wanted him to personally design the aesthetics, lighting, and vibe of the entire commercial hub. Soon after, Bob was sitting across the table from Allan Chapman, the British billionaire whose private equity firm funded the massive city-building project. Allan, dressed casually in corduroys, peppered Bob with questions about his design philosophy. Impressed by Bob's eclectic vision, they offered him the master contract. Within 90 days, lawyers were deployed, world-class architects were brought out of retirement, and Bob was tasked with physically cutting his existing restaurant into pieces and trucking it to the new mega-city. But Bob, possessing an entrepreneurial brain that refused to shut off, didn't stop at the restaurant. Sitting in a boardroom with the billionaire developers, Bob pitched an insanely audacious idea.

Bob had recently used a private finance loophole to buy a \$2.5 million Bell 407 helicopter, which he leased to a high-risk utility aviation company working for PG&E. He pitched Susan and Allan a wild concept: Why not buy a luxury helicopter specifically for River Islands? "Imagine this," Bob pitched. "Allan lands in his private jet, and our chopper picks him up on the tarmac. Even better, we partner with Del Webb, who is building 900 homes for wealthy retirees here. We offer them exclusive Redwood Tours. They board the helicopter at the community lake at 5:30 PM, fly over the mountains to Allan's private vineyard in Napa Valley for a chef's dinner, and fly back by 9:00 PM." It was a wildly luxurious, million-dollar logistical nightmare involving FAA clearances and Napa noise ordinances—and the executives absolutely loved it. At 70 years old, Bob realized that decades of collecting random, disjointed skills—selling, building, hospitality, and aviation—had beautifully compounded into a legacy project that would literally shape a city long after he was gone.